



Authority Support Required

1 assets are awaiting your Letters of Administration to finalize ownership. These assets require probate authority to complete the transfer process.

[FINALIZE DOCUMENTS](#)[View Asset List →](#)

Strategic Assessment

Secure, Notify, Preserve • Immediately After Death

Court Compliance & Eligibility

Eligibility, Venue, Parties • Before Court Filing

Petition & Authority

Uncontested: Admin Filing → Letters Same Day • County Surrogate's Court Filing

Asset Discovery

Inventory Due Within 90 Days (N.J.S.A. 3B:15-1) • After Letters Issued

Creditor Claims

6-Month Claim Window – First Publication (N.J.S.A. 3B:22-4) • After First Publication

Asset Liquidation

Power of Sale or Court Confirmation • After Inventory Filed

Final Distribution

Class A: Exempt | Class C/D: Waiver Required • After Tax Waivers Received



Strategic Assessment

CURRENT



0/22



Preliminary Asset & Liability Scan

NEXT STEP

Identify known bank accounts, real estate, and major debts. This data is critical for estimating estate value on the petition and determining bond requirements.



Secure the Property

Change locks, forward mail, and ensure the home is protected from theft or damage.

Upload Photos



Identify Minor Beneficiaries

OPTIONAL

Review all heirs and identify any beneficiaries under age 18. Minors require special court protection through a guardian ad litem.

Protect Minors



Evaluate Primary Residence Succession

OPTIONAL

If the estate consists primarily of a primary residence valued under the state's simplified threshold, you may qualify for a simplified succession process.

Check Eligibility



Initial Property Protection

Ensure the decedent's residence is secured, mail is forwarded, and assets are protected from loss or damage.



Notify Social Security Administration

Report the death to stop benefit payments and prevent overpayment recovery.



Death Certificate Obtained



Report Death to SSA



Cancel Credit Cards & Subscriptions

Stop recurring charges and prevent identity theft by closing accounts.

Manage Accounts**Manage Utilities**

Review decedent's utility accounts (electricity, water, gas).

**Conduct Genealogical Search** OPTIONAL

If heirs are unknown or missing, you must perform a formal search to identify all legal beneficiaries. This is required for your final distribution decree.

**Locate Important Documents (Intestate)** OPTIONAL

Since there is no Will, search for insurance policies, real estate deeds, and final account statements to inventory the estate.

Upload Documents**Establish Estate Financial Account**

Open a separate fiduciary account for estate income and expenses once legal authority is obtained.

Death Certificate Obtained



Upload Letters of Authority

Upload EIN

**Managed Payment of Immediate Bills**

Prioritize current utilities, mortgage, and insurance to protect the value of estate assets.

Track Bills**Obtain EIN for the Estate**

Apply for an Employer Identification Number from the IRS. This unique ID is required to open an estate bank account and for all tax filings.

Upload IRS Form SS-4

Apply for EIN Online (IRS)

**File IRS Form 56 (Notice of Fiduciary)**

Formally notify the IRS that you have taken on the role of Executor/Administrator. This ensures that all tax correspondence regarding the decedent is sent to you.

Upload IRS Form 56

Upload Certified Letters of Authority

 Download IRS Form 56**Locate Trust Document & All Amendments**

Find the original signed trust document and any amendments. This is your primary legal authority.

 Upload Original Trust Document Upload All Amendments**Confirm Successor Trustee Designation**

Verify your appointment as successor trustee per the trust terms.

**Sign Trustee Acceptance / Affidavit**

Formally accept your role as successor trustee by signing an acceptance document.

 Upload Trustee Acceptance Form**Prepare Certification of Trust**

Create a Certification of Trust (abstract of trust) to prove your authority to banks and institutions without revealing full trust terms.

 **Death Certificate Obtained** Upload Certification of Trust**Obtain EIN for Trust/Estate**

Apply for an Employer Identification Number from the IRS. Required for opening trust bank accounts and filing tax returns.

 Upload IRS Form SS-4 Apply for EIN Online**File IRS Form 56**

Formally notify the IRS of your fiduciary relationship as successor trustee. This ensures tax notices are sent to you directly.

 Upload IRS Form 56

**Secure Trust Property**

Change locks on real property, forward mail, secure valuables, and ensure insurance coverage remains active.

**Issue Certificate of Trust**

Prepare and notarize a Certificate of Trust to present successor trustee authority to banks.

**UPLOAD MISCELLANEOUS****Court Compliance & Eligibility**

0/11

**Validate Venue and Jurisdiction**

Confirm the decedent's legal domicile and county residency to ensure the petition is filed in the legally appropriate court.

**Screen Fiduciary Eligibility**

Verify that the proposed executor or administrator meets all state-specific legal requirements to serve.

**Validate Interested Parties**

Identify all individuals legally entitled to notice or inheritance, including heirs-at-law, beneficiaries, and devisees.

**Compile Will and Testamentary Proofs**

Gather the original valid will, codicils, and secure witness affidavits or self-proving attestations.

**Identify Protected Persons representation**

Screen the interested party list for minors, incapacitated adults, or unknown heirs that require a court-appointed Guardian ad Litem (GAL).

**Prepare Required Notices and Waivers**

Generate the formal notice plan to serve interested parties, or gather Signed Waivers and Consents to expedite the process.

**Evaluate Need for Temporary Authority**

Determine if preliminary letters or special administration is necessary to protect assets or run a business while formal probate is pending.

**Calculate Court Filing Fees**

Determine the exact statutory filing fee based on the estimated gross value of the probate estate.

**Compile Required Court Form Packet**

Synthesize the official local forms and procedural filing notes required by your specific court into a ready-to-file package.

**File Petition for Guardian Ad Litem**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Request court appointment of a guardian ad litem to represent minor beneficiaries' interests throughout probate.

Death Certificate Obtained

**Obtain Guardian Ad Litem Order**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Receive court order appointing guardian ad litem. Provide guardian with all estate information.



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**Petition & Authority**

0/42

1 ASSET

**File Probate Application with County Surrogate (NJ)**

Submit the probate application to the County Surrogate's Court. NJ probate is handled by the Surrogate in each county for uncontested matters.

 **Death Certificate Obtained**

 Upload Original Will

 Upload Probate Application

 Upload Executor Affidavit

 NJ Judiciary Probate Information

☐ File Application for Administration (NJ)

Submit the administration application to the County Surrogate's Court for intestate estates. Bond is typically required unless waived by all heirs.

 **Death Certificate Obtained**

 Upload Administration Application

 Upload Bond or Waiver

 Upload Next of Kin Affidavit

 NJ Surrogate's Court Forms

☐ File Small Estate Affidavit (NJ)

For NJ estates under \$20,000 (or \$50,000 if surviving spouse is sole heir), file a Small Estate Affidavit to collect assets without formal probate.

 **Death Certificate Obtained**

 Upload Small Estate Affidavit Form

 Upload Asset Information

 NJ Small Estate Information

☐ Calculate NJ Bond Amount (Pre-Filing Estimate) LOCKED

Estimate the NJ bond amount before filing using the preliminary asset scan. NJ calculates bond on PERSONAL PROPERTY only (not real estate): Bond = Personal Property Value + Estimated Annual Estate Income. This estimate is provided to the Surrogate at filing and can be updated after the formal inventory is completed.

☐ Determine Bond Requirement & Waiver Gate (NJ) LOCKED

Determine whether bond is required and whether it can be waived before filing. Two waiver paths: (1) Will waives bond — executor is automatically exempt if the will contains an explicit bond waiver clause; (2) Heir consent — ALL heirs/beneficiaries must sign notarized written consent. If neither path is available, obtain a surety bond before Letters are issued.

☐ File Bond Waiver Affidavit (If Applicable) LOCKED

If all heirs/beneficiaries consent to waive bond, file a Bond Waiver Affidavit with the Surrogate's Court. Each heir must sign and notarize their consent.

**Obtain Bond with Surety (If Required)** LOCKED

If bond cannot be waived, obtain a surety bond from a licensed surety company. The bond guarantees faithful performance of fiduciary duties. Premium is paid annually.

**Consider Bond Without Surety (If Applicable)** LOCKED

NJ allows bond without surety (personal obligation only) if the estate is solvent and all beneficiaries consent. This option has no premium cost but exposes the fiduciary to full personal liability.

**Escalate Contested Probate to Superior Court (NJ)** LOCKED

If the probate is contested, the matter transfers from the County Surrogate to the Superior Court, Chancery Division, Probate Part for litigation.

**Determine Power of Sale Authority (NJ)** LOCKED

Review the will and NJ law to determine if you have power of sale for real property without court confirmation, or if court approval is required.

**File Petition for Probate**

Submit the probate petition and original Will to the court to open the estate case and request appointment as Executor.

✓ Death Certificate Obtained📎 Upload Original Will📎 Upload Petition Form**File Petition for Administration**

Submit the administration petition to the court to open the estate case and request appointment as Administrator (since there is no Will).

✓ Death Certificate Obtained📎 Upload Petition Form**Pay Court Filing Fee** LOCKED

Pay the required court filing fee to process the petition. Fees vary by estate value.

**Submit Oath and Designation** LOCKED

Sign and submit the Oath and Designation form, officially agreeing to serve as the fiduciary.

☐ **Obtain Citation (Contested / Surrogate-Directed Only)** LOCKED

In NJ, Citation is only issued when the Surrogate determines a hearing is necessary — e.g., contested matter, missing heirs, or waivers not obtained. Standard uncontested Surrogate's Court probate does not require a Citation.

☐ **Serve Citation (Contested / Surrogate-Directed Only)** LOCKED

Serve the Citation only if the Surrogate issued one. Not required for standard uncontested NJ Surrogate's Court probate.

☐ **Attend Probate Hearing (Contested / Surrogate-Directed Only)** LOCKED

In NJ, hearings are not required for uncontested Surrogate's Court probate. The Surrogate processes the application administratively. Only attend if the Surrogate schedules a hearing due to a contest or other issue.

☐ **Attend Administration Hearing (Contested / Surrogate-Directed Only)** LOCKED

In NJ, hearings are not required for uncontested Surrogate's Court administration. The Surrogate processes the application administratively. Only attend if the Surrogate schedules a hearing.

☐ **Obtain Letters Testamentary (NJ)** LOCKED

After the County Surrogate approves the probate application, Letters Testamentary are issued — typically at the time of filing for uncontested matters. No hearing is required.

☐ **Obtain Letters of Administration (NJ)** LOCKED

After the County Surrogate approves the administration application, Letters of Administration are issued — typically within a few days of filing for uncontested matters. No hearing is required unless the Surrogate directs one.

☐ **File {{smallEstateTerm}}**

Use the {{smallEstateTerm}} to bypass court probate when probate assets are below {{smallEstateThreshold}} ({{smallEstateCitation}}).

 **Death Certificate Obtained**



 **Upload Affidavit Form**

**File Spousal Property Petition**

Request court order to transfer property to surviving spouse without full probate.

✓ Death Certificate Obtained



Upload Petition Form

Start Spousal Path

**Give Notice of Hearing**

OPTIONAL



LOCKED

Notify all interested parties about the court hearing date for the petition.

**Obtain Spousal Property Order**

OPTIONAL



LOCKED

Receive signed court order confirming property ownership transfer to spouse. Record with county recorder if real estate is involved.

**Issue Certificate of Trust**

OPTIONAL

Formalize successor trustee authority for trust-held assets.



Upload Trust Agreement

**Obtain Business Operating Authority**

If the decedent owned a business, you may need a court order to continue operations and pay employees.

**File Petition to Determine Succession to Real Property**

OPTIONAL

File petition with court to determine who inherits the primary residence without full probate.

✓ Death Certificate Obtained



Upload Petition Form



Upload Property Deed



About Succession Petitions

Start Succession

**Give Notice of Hearing**

OPTIONAL



LOCKED

Notify all interested parties of the hearing date for the succession petition.

**Obtain Order Determining Succession to Real Property**

OPTIONAL



LOCKED

Receive court order determining property succession. Record order with county recorder.

**Track Special Notice Requests**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Maintain list of all parties who have requested special notice. You must serve them copies of ALL court filings.

**Serve All Special Notice Recipients**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Each time you file a document with the court, serve copies by mail on all parties who requested special notice.

**Avoid Bond Cost**

LOCKED

Obtain signatures from all heirs to waive the bond requirement, then file the completed waiver with the court.

**Obtain Order Waiving Bond**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Verify that the court has officially waived the bond requirement, typically reflected in a separate Order or the Order for Probate.

**Respond to Objections**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

If someone files an objection to the petition or will, you must respond formally and prepare for contest hearing.

**Attend Will Contest Hearing**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Appear in court for hearing on objection. Be prepared to present evidence supporting will validity.

**Resolve Will Contest**

OPTIONAL

LOCKED

Obtain court ruling on objection. If will is upheld, proceed with probate. If invalidated, estate becomes intestate. Contested probate can extend the timeline by 6-24 months.

**Identify All Trust Beneficiaries**

Review the trust to identify all current and remainder beneficiaries. Include contingent beneficiaries.



Upload Beneficiary List



Send Statutory Notice to Beneficiaries

State law typically requires formal notice to beneficiaries and heirs within a specific timeframe (e.g., 30–90 days).



Upload Notice Letters



Upload Certified Mail Receipts



Notify State Health Agencies

The trustee must notify the state Department of Health or Medicaid recovery agency to allow for potential recovery claims.



Respond to Trust Copy Requests

Beneficiaries have the right to request a copy of the trust. Respond within the timeframe specified by state law.



Flag Minor Beneficiaries

Identify any beneficiaries under age 18. Distributions to minors require special handling.



Monitor Statutory Contest Period

Wait for the statutory contest period to expire before making final distributions. Document any contests or concerns raised.



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Asset Discovery

0/16



Spousal Property Order required

Upload Documents →



Creditor Claims

0/19



Verify Creditor Notice Exemption

Surviving spouses may be exempt from standard creditor notice if they assume personal liability for decedent's debts.

 [State spousal exemption statute](#)

☐ **FIDUCIARY RISK: Statutory Debt Priority**

Assess creditor claims and potential debts under the statutory priority rules applicable in your jurisdiction (often including administration expenses and taxes before unsecured debts).

☐ **Publish Notice to Creditors (If Required)** OPTIONAL

If required or strategically beneficial in your jurisdiction, publish a notice to creditors using the court-approved or locally accepted format. Publication rules, timing, and whether it affects creditor deadlines vary by state and county.

 [Upload Draft notice text \(as applicable\)](#)

 [Upload Case/filing details \(if applicable\)](#)

☐ **Notify Known Creditors**

Notify known creditors as appropriate and document your outreach (e.g., banks, credit cards, medical providers). Requirements and best practices vary by jurisdiction.

 [Upload Creditor notice template \(if used\)](#)

 [Upload Creditor contact list / notice log](#)

☐ **International Fiduciary: W-8BEN/W-8CE Assessment**

For non-resident executors or beneficiaries, determine U.S. tax withholding requirements and treaty eligibility.

☐ **International Fiduciary: ITIN Acquisition Protocol**

Identify foreign beneficiaries without a SSN/ITIN. Coordinate acquisition of U.S. Individual Taxpayer Identification Numbers to avoid maximum backup withholding on distributions.

☐ **Evaluate Estate Solvency**

Compare total estate assets to total liabilities, taxes, and administration/funeral expenses to determine whether the estate appears solvent or insolvent.

☐ **Monitor State-Specific Creditor Exposure Period**

Monitor the creditor exposure timeline applicable in your jurisdiction. The trigger event and timing vary by state and case type. Avoid final distributions until creditor risk is appropriately

managed (often by holding reserves and documenting claim handling).

6-Month Claim Window – Triggered by First Publication (N.J.S.A. 3B:22-4)

In New Jersey, creditors have 6 months from the date of the first publication of notice to present claims (N.J.S.A. 3B:22-4). The clock starts from first publication, not from Letters issuance.

Review Submitted Claims

Examine each creditor claim for validity, amount, and supporting documentation.

Review Claims

Document Claim Evaluation & Decision

Evaluate each creditor claim and document your decision (allowed, partially allowed, disputed/rejected) with supporting rationale and evidence. Claims handling procedures vary by state and case type.

Dispute or Reject Claims (If Applicable) LOCKED

If a claim is incorrect, unsupported, or disputed, follow your state's procedure to dispute, reject, or negotiate the claim. Keep written documentation of the basis and supporting evidence.

Pay Approved Claims (By Statutory Priority) LOCKED

Pay valid debts in the statutory priority order applicable in your jurisdiction (commonly including administration costs, taxes, secured debts, then unsecured claims). Document each payment and retain receipts.

Document Proof of Creditor Notice (If Applicable)

If your jurisdiction requires proof of creditor notice (publication and/or direct notice), retain and submit the required proof in the format your court or process expects. Even when not required to file, maintaining proof supports a defensible administration record.

 Upload Notice log

 Upload Proof documents (if applicable)

Creditor Exposure Assessment

Review known debts and potential claims against the trust estate. This is a silent legal check, not formal probate publication.



Pay Funeral & Last Illness Expenses

These are typically the first obligations to pay from trust assets.



Upload Funeral Invoice



Upload Medical Bills



Pay Ongoing Property Expenses

Maintain trust property by paying mortgage, property taxes, insurance, and utilities from trust accounts.



Evaluate Trust Solvency

Compare total trust assets against all known and potential liabilities to determine solvency status.



Pay Valid Debts

Pay legitimate debts from trust accounts according to trust terms and state priority rules.



UPLOAD MISCELLANEOUS



Asset Liquidation

0/13



Obtain Court Approval for Minor Distributions

Distributions to minors usually require a guardianship or court order to be placed in a blocked account.



Present Letters to All Institutions

Submit certified Letters of Authority to every bank, brokerage, and insurance company.



Death Certificate Obtained



Upload Letters of Authority



Transfer Financial Accounts



LOCKED

Move stocks, bonds, and cash to estate account or directly to beneficiaries.

**Complete Property Sale & Transfer**

If the estate owns real property and a sale is needed, confirm fiduciary authority and any required court authorization in your jurisdiction before signing a contract. Complete closing, deposit proceeds into the estate account, and retain all closing and tax documents.



Upload Closing statement (HUD-1/CD/ALTA)



Upload Deed or transfer instrument



Upload Tax/withholding documents (if any)

Finalize Sale**File Form 1041 (Fiduciary Income Tax)**

Report income, deductions, and credits for a trust or estate that has gross income of \$600 or more in a tax year.

**Issue Schedule K-1 to Beneficiaries**

Provide beneficiaries with their share of income, deductions, and credits to report on their individual tax returns.

**Pay Final Taxes** 🕒 Check Deadline

File final individual 1040, estate 1041, and any estate tax returns.



Upload All Tax Documents

**Prepare Final Accounting** 🔒 LOCKED

Document all income, expenses, and distributions for court review.

**File Decedent's Final Form 1040**

File the decedent's final individual income tax return for the year of death.



Upload Form 1040



Upload W-2s



Upload 1099s

**Determine Post-Death Tax Posture**

A revocable trust becomes irrevocable at death. Determine whether it's now a grantor trust, complex trust, or simple trust for tax purposes.

**Evaluate Estate Tax Return Requirement**

Determine if Form 706 is required based on total estate value, including trust assets.

 Upload Form 706 (if required)



Obtain Tax Clearances

Confirm all taxes are paid before making final distributions to beneficiaries.



Prepare Trust Accounting

Create a comprehensive accounting of all receipts, disbursements, and distributions for beneficiaries.

 Upload Trust Accounting Statement

 **UPLOAD MISCELLANEOUS**



Final Distribution

0/20



Complete liquidation first

View Assets →

Action Plan

YOUR COMPLETE 6-PHASE GUIDE

0%

0/143 TASKS

